



Photographs by DAVID LOMBEIDA For The Times
PADILLA García, 30, left, and Antonio Hernandez, 28, unload avocados in San Ángel Zurumucapio, Mexico.

Mail ballot plan is halted again

‘Disenfranchisement more than likely,’ judge says in blocking Trump’s postal rules.

By KEVIN RECTOR

A federal judge again blocked the U.S. Postal Service from enacting President Trump’s sweeping new mail ballot rules for the November election, finding that the Postal Service lacks such authority over elections and that neither it nor states such as California are capable of implementing the changes without causing chaos and disenfranchising voters.

U.S. District Judge Indira Talwani noted that election officials from across the country told the court that it is “likely impossible” to comply with the rules, which “makes disenfranchisement more than likely, if not probable” if the Postal Service were to proceed with them.

The Trump administration and 12 Republican-led states that are supportive of the new Postal Service rules quickly appealed the Friday decision that night to the U.S. 1st Circuit Court of Appeals.

Talwani’s order — her latest of several halting the plan this summer — came after a Postal Service whistleblower alleged the agency’s new computer systems for the project are fundamentally flawed, a top Postal Service official acknowledged a key online portal was unfinished and the Trump administration filed an emergency petition asking the U.S. Supreme Court to allow the plans to [See Ballots, A8]

Avocados were a lifeline — and then a bitter fruit

Growers in a Mexican village are forced to form militias to protect their land from cartel violence

By Kate Linthicum

SAN ÁNGEL ZURUMUCAPIO, Mexico — Óscar García slowed his truck as he passed the checkpoint of paramilitaries who now guard his town, calling out the nicknames of several of the masked men toting semiautomatic rifles. They waved him through.

His grandfather, Francisco, 74, who rode beside him in a straw cowboy hat, shook his head. This region had once been peaceful, if poor.

“The avocados changed everything,” he said. The explosive growth of the avocado industry has brought enormous wealth to this stretch of western Mexico. “But it also brought terror,” Francisco said.

Danger lurked in the shady groves of avocado trees that stretched on the mountainsides as far as the eye could see. It had touched their town, and their family.

Oscar turned off the winding highway and up a rutted dirt road lined with orchards. He is only 18, but it is his job now to care for his family’s farm. [See Avocados, A16]



MICHOACÁN STATE has become the center of global avocado production.

In Burbank, a home fit for influencers

Creator-run studios bloom as traditional film production shrinks

By CERYS DAVIES



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times
A PODCAST SET at the new 32,000-square-foot Burbank studio of creator-run Smosh Productions.

The exterior of the two-story, beige-colored building looks like any other drab office space near the Hollywood Burbank Airport. But on a recent weekday afternoon, the inside was bustling with activity: Hairstylists carried brightly colored wigs between soundstages, a prop artist was building a fake leg for an upcoming video, and YouTube stars gathered in a lobby, fidgeting with their phones while they waited to film their next scene.

They were among more than 100 employees of Smosh Productions, which this spring moved into the 32,000-square-foot facility, from a much smaller location in the city, to accommodate its programming needs.

It’s the latest creator-run company deepening its roots in Burbank, a neighborhood long defined by such iconic studios as Disney, Warner Bros. and Universal Pictures.

Another influencer-led company that expanded [See Burbank, A12]

Gun store near day care has a city up in arms

By HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS

For over a decade, Goodland Guns operated in an unassuming strip mall in Old Town Goleta, where it sold handguns, rifles and ammo two doors down from the bustling original location of the national Habit Burger & Grill chain.

The firearms retailer never got any formal complaints at that location, ac-

cording to city officials in Goleta, an affluent Santa Barbara County coastal town.

But this summer, Goodland Guns moved to a new location next to a day-care center, where it now shares a fence with the playground. The move stunned and outraged families in Goleta — a place traumatized by mass shootings — and made it the latest California city to contemplate its own restrictions on gun stores.

Goleta is where, in 2006, a former postal worker killed a former neighbor, then fatally shot six employees at a mail sorting facility where she once worked before killing herself.

And it is where 22-year-old Elliot Rodger bought his first gun — a Glock 34 semi-automatic pistol purchased at another store, Goleta Valley Gun and Supply — for use in his 2014 rampage in neighboring Isla Vista, where he killed six UC Santa

Barbara students before taking his own life.

“We are a community that has been touched by significant gun violence,” said Ethan Bertrand, board president for the Goleta Union School District, which has an elementary school campus half a mile west of Goodland Guns’ new space.

“Parents and their children do not want the visible reminder of gun violence and the fear that comes [See Gun store, A9]

Voter backlash to data centers hits California and midterms

It’s a bipartisan flash point driven by fears of rising costs and environmental risks.

By JUSTINE MCDANIEL

HANFORD, Calif. — Darian Orduno bounced her baby boy on her chest, looking down at his thick black hair and bright eyes. What might pollution from a data center do, she wondered, to his growing lungs?

That question had brought Orduno, 25, to a community meeting opposing a possible data center here, and her fears, she said, likely would influence her vote in the midterm election too.

“I just had him, and now it’s concerning if he’s going to be able to grow up here,” Orduno said, or “if I’m going to have to relocate.”

As about 100 residents filed into a church for the meeting in late August, under a Central Valley sky hazy with air pollution, many shared the same worries — that a facility pitched for the local fairgrounds could further worsen the

area’s air quality and strain its water supply.

Nationwide, such concerns are fueling a backlash to data centers from both the left and the right as tech companies flood the country with thousands of proposals for the facilities in nearly every state from California to Maine.

Data centers have become an unusually bipartisan flash point in the midterm elections, as candidates race to delineate policy platforms and respond to public opinion. The issue stands to influence swing voters and motivate turnout at the polls.

Here in the 22nd District, home to the state’s most competitive congressional race, how significantly the issue will affect voters’ decisions remains to be seen. But one thing is clear: Anxiety about data centers is mounting.

“It’s a national concern, it’s now a state concern, and now it’s bled into the local concern,” Hanford Mayor Mark Kairis said. “It’s a very emotionally charged issue right now.”

Demand for data centers, which house the computer [See Data centers, A10]

Jews divided over state recognition of ethnic identity

By HANNAH FRY

California is poised to be the first in the nation to allow people to identify their Jewish heritage on state forms, sparking debate within the community about identity and the merits of being singled out.

Some Jews believe the move would help people understand the community better, particularly on issues such as health and hate crimes. But some are wary about providing too much information given the history of government-sanctioned persecutions against Jewish people.

The state recognizes nearly 50 racial and ethnic identities for data collection, but it considers Jewish identity only as a religion, not an ethnicity.

Senate Bill 1387, which lawmakers passed Aug. 31, seeks to require state agencies to include a box for Jewish ethnicity on all demo-

graphic data forms, ranging from public assistance programs to college applications.

The goal is to improve the accuracy of state data to better understand the needs of Jewish communities, according to the bill’s author, state Sen. Henry Stern (D-Los Angeles). The bill, which received broad support in the Assembly and Senate, will head to Gov. Gavin Newsom’s desk in the coming weeks for a signature or veto.

The proposed law has gone beyond data collection within the Jewish community, prompting discussions and disagreements over whether being Jewish is religious, cultural or a blend of many things. For some, it has evoked anxiety about the historical dangers of tracking Jews.

Stern doesn’t mind the debate. In fact, he says, it speaks to a core part of Jewish identity.

“I love that the Jewish [See Ethnicity, A10]

Loaded Rams ready to run the table

The team can cap a 20-0 season with another Super Bowl win at SoFi, Bill Plaschke writes. **SPORTS, D1**

Feminist Robin Morgan dies

Former child star became a poet, editor and leading activist alongside her friend Gloria Steinem. **NATION, A7**

A new effort to push out Essayli

Public defenders in L.A. cite recent ruling by 9th Circuit Court of Appeals in a similar situation in Nevada. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Rain, a thunderstorm. L.A. Basin: 82°/71° **B7**



7 85944 10300 9



Illustration by KISSI USSUKI For The Times

Lively fall lineup to spice things up

Greet a new season with fresh picks in film, on TV and stage, plus music, dance, art and books. **ENTERTAINMENT**

Opinion Voices A14
Obituaries B3, B6